

That afternoon crash you get like clockwork

8 findings · 11-step checklist · 1 myth · 7 sources · [cheatgrid.com](#)

Afternoon crashes like this aren't about your lunch, and they don't mean you're behind on sleep. Your body's clock builds this dip into the day, and **it lifts on its own** before evening.

THE GOAL

Get through the dip without mistaking it for something wrong with you, and keep **your hardest task** outside this window.

CHECKLIST

The moment your focus drops hard in the afternoon and you reach for something to fix it right at your desk.

- ☐ Stop at a safe point in what you're doing, and note exactly where, so you can pick it back up.
- ☐ If a reply feels urgent, hold it off if you can with a line like "I'll get back to you on this."
- ☐ If you can't get away for long, stand up and move for a minute: walk to get water, step outside, or head down the hall.
- ☐ Get natural or bright light on your face if you can: stand near a window or step outside for a moment.
- ☐ Silence notifications on your phone and computer for the length of your break, so it's an actual break.
- ☐ Give the break a stopping point, like a five-minute timer or "until the kettle boils."
- ☐ Switch to one task that needs **less concentration** than what tripped you up, like sorting easy emails or filing, until the dip passes.
- ☐ If you find a longer quiet stretch and somewhere to lie down, nap instead: set an alarm before you close your eyes.
- ☐ Get a glass of water once you're back at your desk, before you pick your work back up.
- ☐ Write down the time the crash hit and what you were doing, so you can check next week whether it's the same slot and task.
- ☐ Go back to what you paused, starting from the exact spot you noted.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1 Willpower isn't the problem** here: your body clock makes it as hard to stay awake as being short on sleep.
- 2** The early-afternoon fog isn't only a feeling: it's about as big a dip as being awake very late at night.
- 3** Feeling foggy after lunch doesn't prove you're sleep-deprived: brain activity moves in the opposite direction instead of matching it.

What's actually behind it

KNOW

Lunch isn't the trigger. This dip shows up even when someone skips it entirely and loses track of time.

Tweaking your order can feel like solving it, but the dip is rooted in your body's clock, not because of your last meal. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Willpower isn't the problem here: your body clock makes it as hard to stay awake as being short on sleep.

Researchers kept people on a schedule disconnected from clocks for over a month and still found this same, built-in pull each day. [Source 2](#)

What it costs you, and what it doesn't mean about you

KNOW

The early-afternoon fog isn't only a feeling: it's about as big a dip as being awake very late at night.

Volunteers drove a simulator at several times of day, and driving performance dipped about as much in the early afternoon as late at night. [Source 3](#)

KNOW

Feeling foggy after lunch doesn't prove you're sleep-deprived: brain activity moves in the opposite direction instead of matching it.

People measured after lunch and separately after a night with no sleep showed brain-activity patterns pointing in opposite directions. [Source 4](#)

What actually helps, and what doesn't

DON'T

Don't count on a nap to fully cancel out a short night: it can clear the fog for a while, but the pull can return before your day ends.

A short rest can lift alertness for a while, but the sleep you actually missed last night doesn't get made up this way. [Source 5](#)

DON'T

Don't treat a long nap as free: if today's nap runs long, it costs you some of the drive that's supposed to help you fall asleep tonight, feeding tomorrow's version of the same crash.

Sleep pressure builds up all day to help you fall asleep at night, and a long nap spends some of it early. [Source 5](#)

DO

Use a bright or blue-toned light break as a real tool during the dip: reviewed experiments show it measurably lifts alertness, rather than just caffeine or waiting it out.

A review of many experiments found brighter or blue-toned light generally raised people's alertness, though the effect varied by conditions. [Source 6](#)

KNOW

A walk or a bright-light break can lift how alert you feel, but the evidence for it sharpening your hardest thinking work is much shakier.

The same review found light's effect on feeling alert was more consistent than its effect on harder thinking tasks. [Source 6](#)

Myths worth retiring

MYTH

Feeling drowsy after eating happens because your body sends blood away from your brain to help digest the meal.

ACTUALLY

Your brain doesn't run out of blood. Its supply barely changes after eating, and the drowsiness more likely comes from gut hormones and nerve signals reaching your **brain's sleep centers**. [Source 7](#)

Sources

1. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15892914/>
2. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/8190360/>
3. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/9248501/>
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7. <https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/15488646/>

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Tiredness and energy in the day at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

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